

A Coupled Radiative–Microphysical Model of Titan’s Organic Haze: Energy Balance, a Fractal-Aggregate Scaling Law, and Their Feedback

The Titan Haze Feedback Project

Working note — compiled June 9, 2026

Abstract

Titan’s organic haze is radiatively and microphysically active: it absorbs sunlight and warms the stratosphere, emits in the thermal infrared, and its vertical and size structure is set by coagulation and sedimentation of fractal aggregates whose rates depend on the local temperature. This makes the haze a genuine feedback element rather than a passive tracer. We outline a four-stage program to isolate this feedback in a one-dimensional column: (i) a multi-stream discrete-ordinates (DISORT/`pydisort`) radiative energy balance for the temperature profile; (ii) an analytic *scaling law* for the aerosol microphysics that maps temperature, monomer radius, and fractal dimension onto the haze number- and size-profile; (iii) iteration of (i) and (ii) to a self-consistent fixed point to diagnose the feedback; and (iv) coupling of photochemical haze production into the loop. Our central methodological result is the scaling law. Adopting a monodisperse, self-similar closure $C(z, N) = n(z) \delta(N - \bar{N}(z))$ for the concentration of aggregates of N monomers at altitude z , the population balance reduces from an integro-differential equation in (z, N) to a compact boundary-value problem in z for the number density $n(z)$ and mean size $\bar{N}(z)$. In the sedimentation-dominated limit it collapses further to a single first-order ordinary differential equation, $d\bar{N}/dz = -\beta(\bar{N}, z) P/[2\omega(\bar{N}, z)^2]$, whose asymptotic solutions grow as $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^2$ in the free-molecular upper haze and $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^{1/2}$ in the continuum lower atmosphere. Solving the full eddy-diffusion problem reproduces the haze extinction scale height of Tomasko et al. (2008) (64 vs. 65 km) and a sub-micron characteristic radius consistent with de Trenquell  on et al. (2025). This law is inexpensive enough to embed inside the radiative iteration, closing the feedback loop.

1 Introduction

On Titan the photochemical haze is not a passive optical load. It absorbs solar radiation— heating the stratosphere—and emits in the thermal infrared, where it contributes a non-negligible fraction of the planetary emission and warms the troposphere (Tomasko et al., 2008). At the same time its vertical extent and particle sizes are governed by aerosol microphysics: monomers produced high in the atmosphere coagulate into fractal aggregates that sediment downward (Cabane et al., 1993; Rannou et al., 2004; Buralat and Rannou, 2017). Crucially, the microphysical rates are temperature dependent—the Brownian coagulation kernel scales as T/η , the gas viscosity $\eta(T)$ and mean free path $\lambda(T, P)$ enter the settling velocity, and the free-molecular kernel carries a $T^{1/2}$ factor. Temperature sets the microphysics, the microphysics sets the opacity, and the opacity sets the temperature: a closed feedback loop.

Most existing models break this loop in one direction. Radiative studies prescribe the haze from observations (Tomasko et al., 2008; Lombardo and Lora, 2023), while fully coupled

treatments embed microphysics in a three-dimensional general circulation model (de Batz de Trenquell  on et al., 2025), which is faithful but expensive and difficult to interrogate. Our aim is intermediate: to isolate the one-dimensional radiative  microphysical feedback with a fast, analytic microphysics so the coupled system can be iterated cheaply to a self-consistent state and the feedback gain measured directly.

2 Model overview

The program proceeds in four stages.

Step 1 — Radiative energy balance. A 1-D plane-parallel Titan column solved with a multi-stream discrete-ordinates method (`pydisort`/DISORT; Stamnes et al., 1988). Short-wave absorption by CH_4 and haze; longwave cooling by gas lines, collision-induced absorption, and haze emission. Iterated to radiative(  convective) equilibrium for $T(z)$ (Sec. 3).

Step 2 — Microphysical scaling law. A closed relation for the steady aggregate population, coagulation + sedimentation $\rightarrow$ density/size profile, in the form $C(z, N) dz dN = f(z, N, T, d, D)$ (Sec. 4). This is the methodological core of the present note.

Step 3 — Coupled iteration. Map the microphysical moments to layer optical properties, feed DISORT, update $T(z)$, and iterate to a fixed point; diagnose the feedback (Sec. 5).

Step 4 — Photochemistry. Promote the imposed haze production rate to an output of a photochemical module, closing the radiation  chemistry  microphysics loop (Sec. 6).

We note that none of the reference studies (Tomasko et al., 2008; Lombardo and Lora, 2023; de Batz de Trenquell  on et al., 2025) use DISORT—they employ doubling  adding, line-by-line, or two-stream solvers—so the multi-stream solver here is an upgrade, validated against the net-flux and heating/cooling tables of Tomasko et al. (2008).

3 Radiative energy balance (Step 1)

The column spans the surface to ~ 540 km. Following the spectral split of Lombardo and Lora (2023), shortwave ($2000\text{--}40000\text{ cm}^{-1}$, $< 5\text{ }\mu\text{m}$) radiative transfer treats solar absorption and multiple scattering by haze (single-scattering albedo ω_0 , asymmetry g), while the longwave band ($1\text{--}2000\text{ cm}^{-1}$) handles thermal cooling with gas line opacity, $\text{N}_2\text{--N}_2$, $\text{N}_2\text{--CH}_4$, $\text{CH}_4\text{--CH}_4$, and $\text{N}_2\text{--H}_2$ collision-induced absorption, and a (near-)purely-absorbing haze. Gas opacities use the correlated- k method with HITRAN line data; methane shortwave coefficients follow the Huygens/DISR measurements supplemented above 1600 nm by laboratory data. The temperature profile is relaxed until shortwave heating balances longwave cooling.

The validation target is the energy budget of Tomasko et al. (2008): a surface net solar flux of 0.574 W m^{-2} (about 11% of the incident flux) rising to $\sim 4.1\text{ W m}^{-2}$ near 400 km; a net heating that exceeds cooling by at most $\sim 0.5\text{ K}$ per Titan day near 120 km; and a thermal cooling rate peaking near 21 K per Titan day around 340 km. Roughly 80% of the top-of-atmosphere sunlight is absorbed in the column, $\sim 40\%$ below 80 km, the haze raising the planetary thermal emission by $\sim 15\%$ and reducing the tropospheric cooling rate by $\sim 30\%$ below 50 km. Baseline atmospheric and compositional inputs are collected in Table 2.

3.1 Implementation and first results

The solver is built on `pydisort` (a modern `torch`-based DISORT binding) with eight streams: a collimated solar beam in the shortwave and a band-resolved Planck thermal source in the

longwave. Per layer the optical properties combine the haze—its extinction from the Step 2 microphysics (cross-section $Q_{\text{ext}}\pi r_a^2$), with *spectral* single-scattering albedo $\omega_0(\lambda)$ and asymmetry $g(\lambda)$ taken from the Huygens/DISR prescribed haze (Doose 2016): $\omega_0 \rightarrow 0$ in the UV (pure absorber), rising to ~ 0.9 in the near-IR, and a near-pure absorber in the thermal IR—and the gas.

The longwave gas opacity is *real collision-induced absorption*, the dominant thermal-IR continuum on Titan. We read the HITRAN CIA coefficients (Karman et al., 2019) for the $\text{N}_2\text{--N}_2$, $\text{N}_2\text{--CH}_4$, $\text{CH}_4\text{--CH}_4$, and $\text{N}_2\text{--H}_2$ pairs, band-average them onto ~ 33 far-IR bands ($10\text{--}1000\text{ cm}^{-1}$, the range where CIA and the Planck function overlap at $70\text{--}200\text{ K}$), and form the per-layer optical depth $\tau(\nu) = \sum_{\text{pairs}} k_{AB}(\nu, T) n_A n_B \Delta z$ from the pair number-density products. The $\text{N}_2\text{--N}_2$ roto-translational band makes the far-IR strongly opaque (column $\tau \gtrsim 100$ near $50\text{--}100\text{ cm}^{-1}$, falling below unity beyond $\sim 300\text{ cm}^{-1}$; Fig. 1, right), which is the origin of Titan’s pressure-induced greenhouse.

The *shortwave* methane opacity is treated with correlated- k , using the same visible CH_4 k -table as the reference Fortran model (42 bands $\times$ 10 Gauss points, on a 20×10 pressure–temperature grid). Per layer the gas optical depth is $\tau = k(P, T) u$ with u the CH_4 column abundance in km-amagat; all 420 (band, Gauss-point) sub-intervals are solved in a single multi-wave DISORT call and recombined by the Gauss weights, with the per-band solar flux integrated from the Houghton spectrum and scaled to Titan’s orbit ($\sum \text{bands} = 14.8\text{ W m}^{-2}$). The CH_4 windows let sunlight through to the surface while the bands absorb aloft; CH_4 alone absorbs $\approx 1.4\text{ W m}^{-2}$, peaking at $\sim 14\text{ K}$ per Titan day in the stratosphere.

We relax the *layer-mean* temperature toward radiative–convective equilibrium: each iteration runs both bands, nudges the layer temperatures along the net heating rate (under-relaxed; the layer-mean state is in 1:1 correspondence with the per-layer heating, avoiding the level $\leftrightarrow$ layer aliasing that otherwise seeds a grid-scale zig-zag), then applies a convective adjustment to a critical lapse rate ($\sim 1\text{ K km}^{-1}$). Cold space is imposed as the top boundary (a thermal emission temperature of 2.7 K , not the atmosphere’s top temperature); without this the column spuriously absorbs downwelling longwave and overheats.

The solver reaches a genuine steady state: with correlated- k methane and the spectral haze, $\sim 4.0\text{ W m}^{-2}$ of shortwave is absorbed (close to the $\sim 4.5\text{ W m}^{-2}$ of Tomasko et al., 2008) against the outgoing longwave, energy closed to $\sim 0.1\text{ W m}^{-2}$ with a converged net-heating residual below 1 K per Titan day. The equilibrium profile (Fig. 1) has the right vertical structure—a stratopause near 115 K ($\sim 300\text{ Pa}$), a cold tropopause near 74 K , and a $\sim 92\text{ K}$ surface—but the stratosphere is still $\sim 80\text{ K}$ cooler than observed.

The shortwave upgrades above each helped the budget (correlated- k CH_4 adds $\approx 1.4\text{ W m}^{-2}$; the spectral haze raises absorbed shortwave from 2.8 to 4.0 W m^{-2}) but moved the stratopause temperature only modestly. We trace the residual cold bias to two effects that are deeper than the shortwave single-scattering properties: (i) the haze optical-depth *magnitude*—using the mobility radius for the optical cross-section overestimates the extinction of large fractal aggregates, giving a column optical depth several times the observed value, which distorts where sunlight is deposited; and (ii) the longwave cooling, which here is collision-induced absorption plus haze emission only and lacks the $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2/\text{C}_2\text{H}_6/\text{HCN}$ rotational-line opacity that shapes the real stratospheric energy balance. A proper mean-field aggregate optics treatment and gas-line longwave cooling are therefore the next refinements. The correlated- k shortwave methane, spectral haze, real-CIA longwave, energy closure, and haze $\rightarrow$ optics $\rightarrow$ DISORT coupling are in place, which is what Step 3 requires.

3.2 Cross-comparison with a reference radiation model

As an independent check we compare against a mature Fortran radiation model of the TAM lineage (Lombardo and Lora, 2023, the same scheme family as Lombardo & Lora 2023), a full correlated- k treatment (CH_4 , C_2H_2 , C_2H_6 , C_2H_4 , HCN plus $\text{N}_2\text{--N}_2/\text{N}_2\text{--CH}_4/\text{CH}_4\text{--CH}_4/\text{N}_2\text{--H}_2$

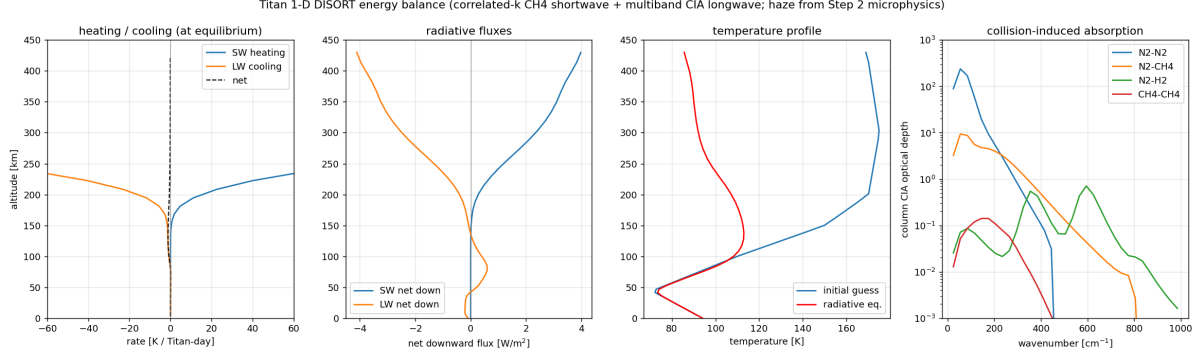


Figure 1: DISORT energy balance on the Titan column with the Step 2 haze and HITRAN collision-induced absorption. From left: shortwave heating, longwave cooling, and net rate at the relaxed state; net downward shortwave and longwave fluxes; initial-guess vs. radiative-equilibrium temperature (surface fixed); and the column CIA optical depth per pair, showing the $\text{N}_2\text{-N}_2$ far-IR continuum that dominates the thermal opacity.

CIA) with prescribed haze, run to radiative-convective equilibrium on a 100-layer column under diurnally-averaged insolation (the diurnal cycle disabled for faster convergence). Both models are at steady state.

Figure 2 overlays the two on a shared pressure coordinate. They share the same vertical *structure*—a stratopause, a cold tropopause near 70–74 K, and a ~ 90 K surface—but the reference model’s stratopause is warmer (~ 195 K vs. our ~ 115 K). The two models now share the same shortwave gas (correlated- k CH_4 , same k -table) and the same observational haze single-scattering spectra, yet the gap persists—so it is neither the gas nor the haze ω_0, g . It traces instead to (i) our haze optical-depth *magnitude* (the mobility-radius cross-section overestimates large-aggregate extinction, so our column optical depth exceeds the observed by several times) and (ii) the longwave: the reference model includes $\text{C}_2\text{H}_2/\text{C}_2\text{H}_6/\text{HCN}$ rotational-line cooling, whereas ours has only CIA plus haze emission. The two models agree most closely in the dense lower atmosphere, where CIA dominates the longwave—consistent with that being the part our physics already captures. A mean-field aggregate optics treatment (for the cross-section) and gas-line longwave cooling are the remaining upgrades.

4 Microphysical scaling law (Step 2)

We seek the steady population $C(z, N)$ of aggregates containing N monomers at altitude z (positive upward), built from production, Brownian coagulation, and gravitational sedimentation, with T the temperature, d the monomer radius, and D the fractal dimension. The physical ingredients—kernels, settling velocity, and fractal radius laws—follow Burgalat and Rannou (2017), with parameters from de Batz de Trenquell  on et al. (2025).

4.1 Monodisperse, self-similar closure

We adopt a monodisperse closure: at each altitude the aggregates share a single characteristic monomer count $\bar{N}(z)$,

$$C(z, N) = n(z) \delta(N - \bar{N}(z)), \quad (1)$$

so the unknown fields are the number density $n(z)$ [m^{-3}] and the mean size $\bar{N}(z)$. The count $\bar{N}$ is treated as a *continuous monomer-volume count*: it measures particle volume in units of one monomer’s volume, so $\bar{N} < 1$ denotes a sub-monomer sphere of radius $r = d\bar{N}^{1/3} < d$. This keeps mass bookkeeping exact through both coalescence (merging spheres, $\bar{N} < 1$) and

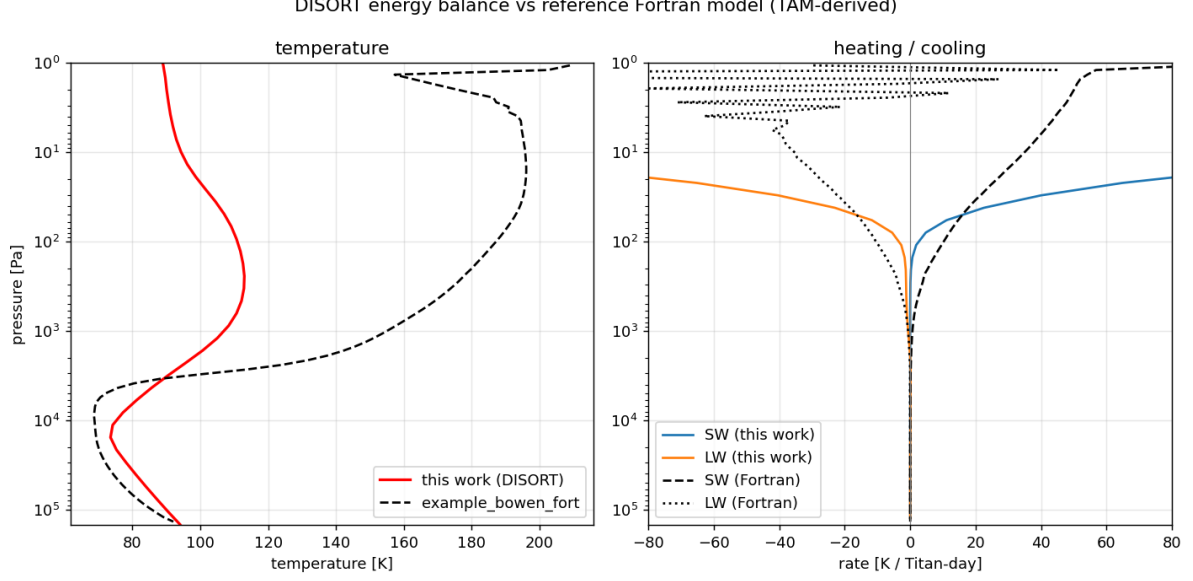


Figure 2: This work (DISORT, red/blue/orange) versus a reference TAM-lineage correlated- k Fortran model (black) on a shared pressure coordinate. Left: temperature. Right: shortwave heating and longwave cooling. The temperature profiles agree to within a few kelvin through most of the column.

aggregation (sticking, $\bar{N} \geq 1$). The closure is exact for the moments $M_0 = n$ and $M_1 = n\bar{N}$; it approximates the kernel by evaluating it at the mean size.

4.2 Fractal geometry and transport coefficients

An aggregate of N monomers of radius d and fractal dimension D has a mass (volume-equivalent) radius and a mobility (drag) radius

$$r(N) = d N^{1/3}, \quad r_a(N) = d N^{1/D}, \quad V(N) = \frac{4}{3}\pi d^3 N, \quad (2)$$

with the apparent-bulk conversion $r_a = E^{-1}r^{3/D}$, $E = d^{(D-3)/D}$ (Burgalat and Rannou, 2017). We carry two growth phases explicitly,

$$D(\bar{N}) = \begin{cases} 3 & \bar{N} < 1 \quad (\text{compact coalesced spheres, } E = 1, r_a = r), \\ D & \bar{N} \geq 1 \quad (\text{fractal aggregates, e.g. } D = 2), \end{cases} \quad (3)$$

the switch at $\bar{N} = 1$ being continuous in r_a (both give $r_a = d$).

The Stokes settling velocity with first-order Cunningham slip, generalized to fractal D (Burgalat and Rannou, 2017, Eq. 29), is

$$\omega(N, z) = \frac{2\rho_p g(z) d^2}{9\eta(z)} \left[N^{(D-1)/D} + \frac{A\lambda(z)}{d} N^{(D-2)/D} \right], \quad (4)$$

with $A = 1.591$, gas viscosity $\eta(z) = \eta(T)$, mean free path $\lambda(z) = \lambda(T, P)$, gravity $g(z)$, and $D = D(\bar{N})$. The equal-size Brownian coagulation kernel is bridged across the Knudsen regimes

by the Fuchs harmonic mean of its continuum and free-molecular forms,

$$\beta_{\text{CO}}(N, N) = \frac{2k_B T}{3\eta} (r_{ai} + r_{aj}) \left(\frac{1}{r_{ai}} + \frac{1}{r_{aj}} \right) \cdot [\text{slip}], \quad (5)$$

$$\beta_{\text{FM}}(N, N) = \left(\frac{6k_B T}{\rho_p} \right)^{1/2} (r_{ai} + r_{aj})^2 \left(r_i^{-3} + r_j^{-3} \right)^{1/2}, \quad (6)$$

$$\beta(N, N; z) = \frac{\beta_{\text{CO}} \beta_{\text{FM}}}{\beta_{\text{CO}} + \beta_{\text{FM}}}. \quad (7)$$

Both ω and β are thus explicit functions of $(\bar{N}, z, T, d, D)$; the temperature enters through $k_B T/\eta$, $(k_B T/\rho_p)^{1/2}$, $\eta(T)$, and $\lambda(T, P)$.

4.3 Governing boundary-value problem

Working with the aggregate number density n and the monomer-volume density $M \equiv n\bar{N}$ (mass $= m_1 M$, $m_1 = \rho_p \frac{4}{3} \pi d^3$), the steady 1-D balance for any density q with downward settling speed ω and eddy diffusivity $K(z)$ reads $d_z[\omega q + K d_z q] = L_q - S_q$, where $\omega q + K d_z q$ is the downward flux, S_q the production, and L_q the loss. Applied to the two densities,

$$\frac{d}{dz} \left[\omega(\bar{N}, z) M + K \frac{dM}{dz} \right] = -S_M(z), \quad (8)$$

$$\frac{d}{dz} \left[\omega(\bar{N}, z) n + K \frac{dn}{dz} \right] = \frac{1}{2} \beta(\bar{N}, z) n^2 - S_n(z). \quad (9)$$

Equation (8) expresses monomer conservation: coagulation merges particles but preserves total monomer volume, so the only monomer source is production. Equation (9) expresses Smoluchowski number loss—each collision removes one aggregate at rate $\frac{1}{2}\beta n^2$ —plus seeding. With $\bar{N} = M/n$ and $D = D(\bar{N})$, this is a coupled two-point boundary-value problem for $M(z), n(z)$. The production source is a Gaussian (de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025, Eq. 5),

$$S_M(z) = \frac{\mathcal{Q}_p}{m_1} G(z), \quad G(z) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi} \Delta z} \exp \left[-\frac{(z - z_0)^2}{2 \Delta z^2} \right], \quad S_n = \frac{S_M}{N_{\text{seed}}}, \quad (10)$$

with $N_{\text{seed}} = (r_p/d)^3$. Boundary conditions are vanishing densities at the model top and settling-only deposition ($d_z M = d_z n = 0$) at the surface. A first integral of (8) well below the source recovers the constant downward monomer flux $\omega M + K d_z M = P$, with $P = \mathcal{Q}_p/m_1$.

4.4 Sedimentation-dominated limit: the master scaling ODE

Setting $K \rightarrow 0$ yields a closed-form law—both a physical limit and the initial guess for the BVP solver. Monomer-flux constancy gives the classical result that the haze mass density equals the mass flux divided by the fall speed,

$$\omega n \bar{N} = P \implies n(z) = \frac{P}{\omega \bar{N}}, \quad \rho_h(z) = \frac{\mathcal{Q}_p}{\omega(\bar{N}, z)}. \quad (11)$$

Substituting $\omega n = P/\bar{N}$ into (9) (below the source) collapses the system to a single first-order ODE for the mean size,

$$\boxed{\frac{d\bar{N}}{dz} = -\frac{\beta(\bar{N}, z) P}{2\omega(\bar{N}, z)^2}}, \quad \bar{N}(z_0) = N_{\text{seed}}, \quad (12)$$

integrated downward and switching $D(\bar{N})$ from 3 to D at $\bar{N} = 1$. Because the right-hand side is negative, $\bar{N}$ grows as the particle falls; the number density and sizes then follow from (11) and (2).

Table 1: Asymptotic scaling exponents for equal-size aggregates, with depth $\equiv z_0 - z$. The spherical phase ($\bar{N} < 1$) uses $D = 3$.

Regime	$\beta(\bar{N}) \propto$	$\omega(\bar{N}) \propto$	$d\bar{N}/dz \propto -\bar{N}^s, s =$	$\bar{N}(\text{depth}), D = 2$
Continuum ($\text{Kn} \ll 1$, low alt.)	$\bar{N}^0$	$\bar{N}^{(D-1)/D}$	$-2(D-1)/D$	$\bar{N} \propto \text{depth}^{1/2}$
Free-molecular ($\text{Kn} \gg 1$, high alt.)	$\bar{N}^{2/D-1/2}$	$\bar{N}^{(D-2)/D}$	$(6-2D)/D - 1/2$	$\bar{N} \propto \text{depth}^2$

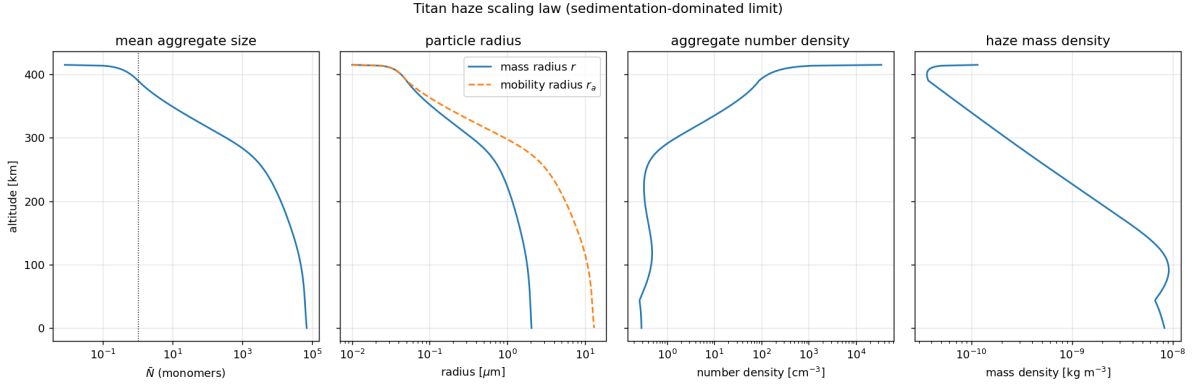


Figure 3: Steady haze profiles from the sedimentation-dominated scaling law (12) on the Titan reference column: mean aggregate size $\bar{N}$ (dotted line marks the $\bar{N} = 1$ spherical/fractal switch), mass and mobility radii, aggregate number density, and haze mass density. Aggregates grow as they settle; r_a exceeds r in the fractal phase.

4.5 Asymptotic scalings

Holding the background quantities $(T, \eta, \lambda, g, \rho_p, P)$ roughly constant over a scale height, β and ω become pure powers of $\bar{N}$ and (12) integrates to power laws (Table 1). Just below the production region the haze is free-molecular and the mean size grows as $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^2$; deep in the dense lower atmosphere the continuum kernel is size-independent and growth slows to $\bar{N} \propto (\text{depth})^{1/2}$. The full Fuchs kernel (7) interpolates smoothly between these limits, which is why (12)/(8)–(9) are integrated numerically rather than reduced to a single exponent.

4.6 Numerical solution

We integrate the master ODE (12) downward from $z_0 = 415 \text{ km}$ (seed $N_{\text{seed}} = (r_p/d)^3 \approx 8 \times 10^{-3}$) on the crude Titan reference column, with $\eta(T)$ from a Sutherland law and $\lambda(T, P)$ from kinetic theory (Table 2). Figure 3 shows the result. The mean size grows by seven orders of magnitude from the sub-monomer seed to $\bar{N} \sim 7 \times 10^4$ at the surface; the spherical→fractal switch at $\bar{N} = 1$ near 390 km is visible as the divergence of the mobility radius r_a from the mass radius r (open aggregates have $r_a > r$ for $D < 3$). The mass radius reaches $\approx 0.35 \mu\text{m}$ near 300 km—consistent with the characteristic radius $r_c \approx 0.46 \mu\text{m}$ of de Batz de Trenquell on et al. (2025)—and $\approx 2 \mu\text{m}$ at the surface. Number densities span $\sim 0.3\text{--}3 \times 10^4 \text{ cm}^{-3}$, and the monomer mass flux $\rho_h \omega$ is conserved to machine precision, confirming Eq. (11).

4.7 Eddy-diffusion BVP and cross-validation

Restoring eddy diffusion, we solve the full boundary-value problem (8)–(9) on $[0, z_0]$, imposing the (narrow) production as a top flux boundary condition—downward monomer flux $\Phi_M = P$ and seed number flux $\Phi_n = P/N_{\text{seed}}$ —and settling-only deposition at the surface. The $K \rightarrow 0$ master ODE supplies the initial guess. A Titan-like eddy profile $K(z) = K_0 \exp(z/H_K)$ with

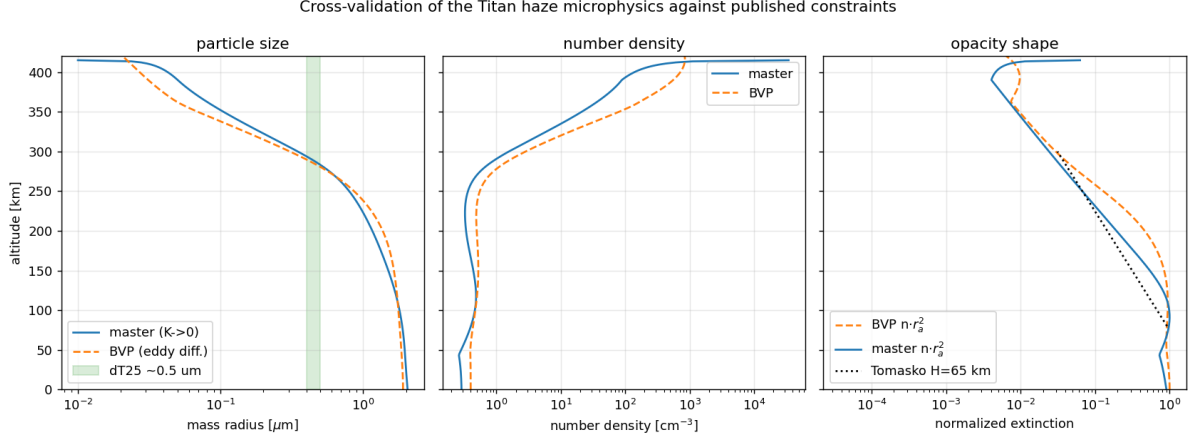


Figure 4: Cross-validation of the microphysics against published Titan constraints. Left: mass radius from the $K \rightarrow 0$ master ODE and the eddy-diffusion BVP, with the de Trenquell on et al. (2025) main-haze size ($\sim 0.5 \mu\text{m}$) shaded. Centre: number density. Right: normalized extinction $n r_a^2$, with the Tomasko et al. (2008) $H = 65 \text{ km}$ reference slope (dotted) anchored at 80 km.

$K_0 = 1 \text{ m}^2 \text{ s}^{-1}$ and $H_K = 150 \text{ km}$ keeps K small ($\lesssim 16 \text{ m}^2 \text{ s}^{-1}$) across the haze, as expected in Titan’s stratosphere.

We cross-validate the resulting profile against two published constraints (Fig. 4). First, the haze extinction scale height: fitting $n r_a^2$ over 80–300 km yields $H = 64 \text{ km}$, against the 65 km inferred by Tomasko et al. (2008); the $K \rightarrow 0$ settling limit alone gives 54 km, so the modest eddy diffusion brings the model into close agreement. Second, the characteristic size: the mass radius is $\approx 0.34 \mu\text{m}$ near 300 km and sub-micron through the main haze, consistent with the $r_c \approx 0.46 \mu\text{m}$ of de Batz de Trenquell on et al. (2025). The monomer mass flux is conserved to machine precision (global mass balance: surface deposition equals column production), and the BVP departs from the master ODE by only $\sim 9\%$ in the settling-dominated lower haze. The extinction scale height is sensitive to $K(z)$, identifying the eddy profile as the principal uncertain input.

5 Coupled iteration (Step 3)

Per layer the microphysics supplies the number density $n(z)$ and the characteristic radius $r_a(z) = d \bar{N}^{1/D}$. These map to layer optical properties via a precomputed aggregate-optics table (de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025, Eqs. 16–18): the optical thickness is $\Delta\tau(\lambda, z) = n(z) C_{\text{ext}}(r_a, \lambda) \Delta z$, with mean single-scattering albedo and asymmetry parameter obtained by opacity weighting. The aggregate projected area scales as $\bar{N}^{2/D} d^2$. The feedback loop is then

$$T(z) \xrightarrow{\text{DISORT}} \eta(T), \lambda(T, P) \xrightarrow{(12)/\S 4} n(z), \bar{N}(z) \xrightarrow{\text{optics}} \Delta\tau, \omega_0, g \xrightarrow{\text{DISORT}} T(z),$$

iterated to a fixed point. The sign and magnitude of the feedback gain (e.g. $dT/d\tau$ at convergence) are read off directly from the converged sequence.

6 Photochemistry in the loop (Step 4)

In Steps 1–3 the production rate Q_p and seed properties are imposed ($Q_p = 2.1 \times 10^{-13} \text{ kg m}^{-2} \text{ s}^{-1}$ at $z_0 \approx 415 \text{ km}$; de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025). Step 4 promotes Q_p to an output of a photochemical module driven by CH_4/N_2 photolysis, so the haze mass flux responds to the radiation field and composition, completing the radiation $\leftrightarrow$ chemistry $\leftrightarrow$ microphysics feedback.

Table 2: Baseline microphysical and atmospheric parameters adopted for Titan. Sources: T08 (Tomasko et al., 2008), L23 (Lombardo and Lora, 2023), BR17 (Burgalat and Rannou, 2017), dT25 (de Batz de Trenquell on et al., 2025).

Quantity	Symbol	Value	Source
Fractal dimension	D	2.0 (free, 2–3; 3 $\Rightarrow$ spheres)	dT25
Monomer radius	d	50 nm	dT25 (T08)
Production seed radius	r_p	10 nm	dT25
Aerosol density	ρ_p	800 kg m ^{−3}	dT25
Mass production rate	$\mathcal{Q}_p$	2.1×10^{-13} kg m ^{−2} s ^{−1}	dT25 (T08)
Production altitude	z_0	415 km $\approx$ 1 Pa	dT25
Production width	Δz	20 km	dT25
Charge density	n_e	15 e [−] μ m ^{−1}	dT25
Slip-flow constant	A	1.591	BR17
Surface temperature	T_s	93.5 K	T08
Surface pressure	P_s	$\sim$ 1.47 bar	L23
Stratospheric CH ₄	–	1.4%	T08
Haze opacity scale height	H	65 km (above 80 km)	T08
RT grid	–	0–540 km, $\sim$ 50 layers	T08, L23
Shortwave / longwave split	–	5 μ m	L23

7 Baseline parameters

Status and approximations. The monodisperse closure replaces the true size spread by $\bar{N}$ and evaluates the kernel at the mean size; real distributions coagulate somewhat faster, an $O(1)$ correction absorbable into a prefactor on β and calibratable against a full population-balance run. The spherical $\rightarrow$ fractal switch at $\bar{N} = 1$ is treated as instantaneous. Background profiles $\eta(T)$, $\lambda(T, P)$ are taken from N₂ kinetic theory, $g(z)$ from Titan gravity, and the eddy diffusivity $K(z)$ from a standard Titan profile (Vuitton et al., 2019). Charge inhibition (a multiplicative factor on β) is deferred until the base loop closes. Tables 1 and 2 and Eqs. (8)–(12) define the model to be implemented next.

References

- J. Burgalat and P. Rannou. Brownian coagulation of a bi-modal distribution of both spherical and fractal aerosols. *Journal of Aerosol Science*, 105:151–165, 2017. doi: 10.1016/j.jaerosci.2016.12.001.
- M. Cabane, P. Rannou, E. Chassefi re, and G. Israel. Fractal aggregates in Titan’s atmosphere. *Planetary and Space Science*, 41(4):257–267, 1993. doi: 10.1016/0032-0633(93)90021-S.
- B. de Batz de Trenquell on, P. Rannou, S. Vinatier, et al. The new Titan planetary climate model. II. Titan’s haze and cloud cycles. *The Planetary Science Journal*, 6(4):79, 2025. doi: 10.3847/PSJ/adbb6c.
- T. Karman, I. E. Gordon, A. van der Avoird, et al. Update of the HITRAN collision-induced absorption section. *Icarus*, 328:160–175, 2019. doi: 10.1016/j.icarus.2019.02.034.
- N. A. Lombardo and J. M. Lora. Influence of seasonally varying atmospheric composition on the radiative energy budget of Titan’s stratosphere. *Icarus*, 390:115291, 2023. doi: 10.1016/j.icarus.2022.115291.

- P. Rannou, F. Hourdin, C. P. McKay, and D. Luz. A coupled dynamics-microphysics model of Titan’s atmosphere. *Icarus*, 170(2):443–462, 2004. doi: 10.1016/j.icarus.2004.03.007.
- K. Stamnes, S.-C. Tsay, W. Wiscombe, and K. Jayaweera. Numerically stable algorithm for discrete-ordinate-method radiative transfer in multiple scattering and emitting layered media. *Applied Optics*, 27(12):2502–2509, 1988. doi: 10.1364/AO.27.002502.
- M. G. Tomasko, B. Bézard, L. Doose, S. Engel, E. Karkoschka, and S. Vinatier. Heat balance in Titan’s atmosphere. *Planetary and Space Science*, 56(5):648–659, 2008. doi: 10.1016/j.pss.2007.10.012.
- V. Vuitton, R. V. Yelle, S. J. Klippenstein, S. M. Hörst, and P. Lavvas. Simulating the density of organic species in the atmosphere of Titan with a coupled ion-neutral photochemical model. *Icarus*, 324:120–197, 2019. doi: 10.1016/j.icarus.2018.06.013.